Job Tool: "When to Refer to Disaster Mental Health" Reference Card

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools
DCS JT Respond/Disaster Mental Health

The "When to Refer to Disaster Mental Health" Reference Card is a resource to help all disaster workers remember what to listen for when talking to clients and when to refer to Disaster Mental Health.

Psychological First Aid instructors and disaster leaders should use the following document to produce individual cards for all disaster workers.

Instructions for producing cards:

Option 1: Use local printing resource to have individual cards created as 2-sided business cards.

Option 2: Print using Red Cross printing resources.

1. Print the following two pages in color and 2-sided (on the same sheet of paper) preferably on card stock or heavy paper.
2. Cut sheets into individual cards.

Distribute one card to each disaster worker during in-person Psychological First Aid trainings or after taking the course via webinar or online.

When to Refer to DMH

American Red Cross

Refer to DMH NOW

- **In danger of harming self/other, CALL 911 NOW**
- Unable to care for self
- Severe emotional distress
- Confusion/disorientation

Refer to DMH ASAP

*Concerning **R**eactions*

- Unexpected reactions to stress
- Family/friends concerned about behavior

*Significant **R**isk Factors*

- Family, friend or pet killed
- Felt threat to life
- Witnessed death/injury
- Separated from family/caregiver
- Community destroyed

***R**esilience/Coping Ability*

- No family/community support
- No financial resources
- Lacks good coping skills

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Refer to DMH By End of Shift

*Concerning **R**eactions*
- Difficulty thinking/concentrating
- Anxiety/nervousness
- Significant physical complaints

*Significant **R**isk Factors*
- Home destroyed
- Assisted with rescue/recovery
- Sheltered in place
- Has severe financial loss

***R**esilience Factors/Coping Ability*
- Some positive coping skills
- Some community/family support

Basic Psychological First Aid
- Take care of yourself
- Make a connection/listen
- Help people be safe
- Be kind, calm and compassionate
- Meet people's basic needs
- Give realistic reassurance
- Encourage good coping
- Help people connect
- Give accurate info
- Refer to DMH
- End conversation

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